## Internet as an Information Source

The Internet is one of the most powerful and widely used information sources in the modern world. It is a vast global network that connects millions of computers, devices, databases, and digital platforms, allowing users to access, create, share, and store information instantly. As an information source, the internet contains an enormous variety of resources—text, images, videos, audio, data, and interactive content produced by individuals, institutions, governments, scholars, and organizations.

The internet is a powerful, flexible, and essential information source that supports academic research, personal learning, communication, and professional development. Its vast content, global accessibility, multimedia features, and real-time updates make it invaluable. However, users must develop strong digital literacy and evaluation skills to use it effectively and responsibly.

### Factors that make internet as an Information Source

#### 1. A Vast Reservoir of Information

The internet contains an almost limitless amount of information published by individuals, organizations, governments, scholars, and corporations. Unlike printed sources that require time to produce and distribute, online information can be uploaded instantly and updated frequently. This makes the internet one of the largest and most dynamic knowledge repositories. Users can find information on virtually any topic—from academic subjects and technical knowledge to entertainment, culture, and personal interests. Its vastness makes it essential for research, learning, and decision-making.

#### 2. Multiple Types of Information Sources

The internet accommodates **primary**, **secondary**, and **tertiary** information sources, making it versatile for different information needs.

- **Primary sources** include raw research data, government documents, interviews, and original reports that provide firsthand information.
- **Secondary sources** such as journal reviews, commentaries, analyses, and summaries help interpret or evaluate primary sources.
- **Tertiary sources** like dictionaries, encyclopedias, indexes, abstracts, and directories assist users in locating or organizing information. This wide range of source types helps users gather both original evidence and interpretive materials for academic and professional work.

**3. Fast and Easy Access**

The internet provides quick access to information without the physical limitations of traditional libraries. Users with a smartphone, computer, or tablet can search for information using search engines like Google within seconds. This convenience reduces the time spent locating materials and increases the efficiency of academic and research activities. It also allows users to access information 24/7 from any location, provided they have internet connectivity.

**4. Supports Multimedia Information**

One of the unique strengths of the internet is its ability to present information in multiple formats such as text, video, audio, animations, graphics, and interactive tools. For example, a student can read an article, watch a video explanation, listen to a podcast, and participate in a simulation—all on the same topic. This multimodal presentation enhances comprehension, supports different learning styles, and can make complex concepts easier to understand.

**5. Enables Scholarly and Academic Research**

Many scholarly resources are published or archived online, making the internet essential for modern academic work. Platforms such as Google Scholar, ResearchGate, institutional repositories, electronic journals, and digital libraries offer access to peer-reviewed articles, theses, dissertations, conference papers, and e-books. These sources provide authoritative information that supports assignments, projects, research papers, and literature reviews. Some materials are open access, reducing financial barriers to research.

**6. Allows User Participation and Knowledge Sharing**

The internet encourages interactive knowledge creation through platforms like blogs, social media, wikis, and online discussion forums. Users can upload articles, comment on posts, share experiences, and collaborate with others across the world. Websites like Wikipedia demonstrate how users can collectively generate and update information. This participatory nature democratizes knowledge and allows individuals without formal publishing power to contribute to global information resources.

**7. Real-Time and Up-to-Date Information (Expanded)**

Unlike printed materials, which may become outdated quickly, the internet allows continuous updating of information. News websites provide real-time updates on politics, weather, health, sports, disasters, and international events. Government portals offer timely policy documents, public announcements, and statistical updates. This real-time characteristic makes the internet essential for staying informed about current trends and developments.

**8. Global Reach and Accessibility**

The internet connects people worldwide, making it a global information system. Users in Nigeria can access information from the United States, Europe, Asia, and other regions in

stantly. This global connectivity fosters cultural exchange, academic collaboration, and international research. It also enables access to resources that may not exist locally, thereby bridging information gaps in developing regions.

**ICT APPLICATION IN LIBRARY AND INFORMATION CENTERS FOR MANAGEMENT AND PROMOTION (Readers' and Technical Section).**

Information and Communication Technology (ICT) has transformed the way libraries and information centers operate, manage resources, and promote services. ICT tools make library operations faster, more accurate, user-friendly, and globally accessible. They enhance both internal management functions and external promotional activities aimed at attracting and engaging users.

It has revolutionized library and information center management by making operations faster, more accurate, and user-friendly. It also enhances promotion and outreach by enabling libraries to connect with users through multiple digital channels. The effective adoption of ICT strengthens library services, increases visibility, and supports academic and research activities in the digital age.

**Meaning of Readers' Services in Libraries**

Readers' services refer to all the library activities and functions that directly assist and interact with users to help them access, use, and benefit from library resources. These are the **front-line services** that involve direct contact with readers, such as circulation, reference services, user education, current awareness, and providing access to both print and electronic materials. The main aim of readers' services is to ensure that users find the information they need easily, receive guidance on how to use library resources, and enjoy a smooth, supportive library experience. In short, readers' services focus on meeting the information needs of users and ensuring their satisfaction through timely, helpful, and personalized assistance.

**ICT Application in Readers' Services**

1. Online Public Access Catalogue (OPAC)

OPAC allows users to search for library materials electronically by title, author, subject, keyword, or call number. It saves time, reduces queues at the circulation desk, and enables users to check availability of books without staff assistance.

2. Electronic Reference Services

ICT enables reference services through email, live chat, WhatsApp, and video calls. Users can ask questions and receive help from librarians in real time, even without being physically present in the library.

3. Access to Electronic Resources

Library users can access e-books, e-journals, online newspapers, databases, and multimedia resources using computers and the internet. This improves research quality and gives readers access to a wider range of materials.

4. User Education and Information Literacy

ICT supports digital tutorials, PowerPoint presentations, YouTube videos, and online guides that teach users how to search databases, evaluate information, and use library tools effectively.

5. Readers' Advisory Services

ICT helps librarians recommend books and resources by using automated suggestions, reading history, user profiles, and online book review platforms. This makes it easier to match readers with relevant materials.

6. **Communication and Notifications**

Libraries use emails, SMS, websites, and social media to inform users about overdue bo oks, new arrivals, holidays, seminars, and library events. This keeps users updated and i mproves communication.

7. **Internet and Computer Access**

Readers can use library computers to browse the internet, type assignments, access onli ne learning platforms, or download materials. This supports academic work and general information access.

**Application of ICT in Library and Information Centers for Management and Promotion**

**Meaning of Technical Services in Libraries**

Technical services refer to the behind-the-scenes activities in the library that involve the **a cquisition, processing, organization, and preparation of information materials** before th ey are made available to users. These are the internal operations that ensure library reso urces are properly selected, purchased, catalogued, classified, labeled, and entered into t he library system. Technical services make library materials easy to locate, retrieve, and use by the public. Because these tasks are mostly done by specialized librarians and are not visible to users, they are called "technical" or "back-room" operations. In summary, te chnical services ensure that every book or information resource is well organized, accura tely recorded, and ready for access on the shelves or online.

**ICT Application in Technical Services**

1. **Library Automation Systems (ILMS)**

ICT supports technical services through Integrated Library Management Systems (ILMS) like Koha and Evergreen. These systems manage cataloguing, acquisitions, serials contr

ol, and circulation electronically, reducing manual workload and errors.

2. **Digital Cataloguing (MARC, Metadata, Z39.50)**

ICT allows cataloguing to be done using digital standards such as MARC records, metad ata formats, and Z39.50 protocols. Librarians can import records, share bibliographic da ta, and maintain uniform cataloguing.

3. **Automated Acquisitions**

Libraries use ICT to order books online, communicate with vendors, process invoices elec tronically, and track materials in real time. This makes acquisition faster and more organ ized.

4. **Serials Management Systems**

ICT helps libraries manage journals, magazines, and newspapers by tracking issues recei ved, renewal dates, and missing issues. This ensures accurate records and reduces subs cription problems.

5. **Barcode and RFID Technology**

ICT uses barcode labels and RFID tags during processing. These improve item identificat ion, speed up circulation, make stock taking easier, and reduce theft or loss of library mat erials.

6. **Digital Preservation**

ICT tools such as scanners, repository software, cloud storage, and digital backup syste ms help preserve electronic documents and digitized materials. This protects records fro m damage or loss of information materials.

7. **Database Management**

ICT supports storage and organization of bibliographic records through databases. This makes it easy to update, retrieve, and maintain accurate information about library materials.

8. **Classification Tools and Software**

ICT provides automated classification tools that assist librarians in assigning call numbers and organizing materials according to systems like DDC and LCC. This improves accuracy and saves time.